Live Trains

How to use your desk

This desk shows passenger trains that are moving now: Amtrak, VIA, and Brightline. Freight trains and city commuter trains are not on this list. It is not a full timetable, and it is not for driving directions. There is no account. Keep it plugged in, and give it your home Wi-Fi.

First time

Plug in the power cable. The screen comes on. The first time, it opens JOIN WIFI.

Tap SCAN and pick your network, or type the name. Type the password on the keyboard. abc switches to capital letters. !# switches to numbers and symbols. SPACE adds a space. DEL removes the last letter. Tap SAVE. You will see saved, then linking.

If your home has two network names and one ends in 5G, use the other name. If the scan says none found, type the name yourself.

Out of the box the station is Fresno. Change it to your own station before you settle in. Tap SETUP along the bottom, then LOCATION, and follow the steps below.

Give it a little while after it joins. The corner says TRAINS while it is still fetching, then LIVE and a number of trains. A minute is normal the first time.

Getting around

Along the bottom are five buttons: LINE, LIST, DEPOT, CLOCK, and SETUP.

Almost every other page has BACK at the top left and HOME at the top right. BACK returns to the page you came from. HOME returns to the map.

Tap one thing, wait for the page to finish drawing, then tap the next.

The map

This is the home screen. Your station is the center. Rings around it are distance, in nautical miles. A nautical mile is a little longer than a regular mile. North is up. N, S, E, and W sit at the edges.

The yellow lines are the passenger routes. Station names sit on those lines.

Each train is a dot with a short line. The line is the direction that train is heading. Its number sits in a small box. Amtrak is the blue mark. VIA and Brightline are the amber mark. A magenta ring means that is the train you have open.

The top left says LIVE and how many trains are in range. LIVE none means the connection is fine and nothing is inside your circle. TRAINS means it is still fetching. train fetch fail means leave it up and it will try again. The clock is at the top right.

ZOOM - and ZOOM + sit above the bottom buttons. They change how far out you are looking. The number in the middle is the range, in nautical miles. You can also pinch with two fingers. Spreading your fingers zooms in. Pinching them together zooms out. Drag the map to look around. A wider range shows more of the route, and the trains sit closer together.

Tap a train, or tap its number, to open that trip.

A train

The big number is the train. Under it is the route, and who runs it when that is known.

departed from is where it started. going to is where it is headed. next stop is the next station on its way.

The next line is the direction it is heading, such as north or southwest. If it is barely moving and no direction was sent, it says stopped. SPEED is miles per hour.

ON TIME means it is not running late. A number of minutes late means it is behind.

If the page says no train, that one has already left your range.

List

LIST opens a page called CORRIDOR. Each row is a train number, where it started and where it is going, and either on time or how many minutes late.

Eight trains fit on the page. If there are more, tap the bottom where it says tap bottom for more. Tap a row to open that train. none in range means nothing is inside the circle you set.

Depot

DEPOT is your station, written out. The code and the city are on the left. NEAREST on the right is the closest train, how far it is, and its next stop.

Under that are up to five trains, nearest first. Tap a row to open that train.

Line

LINE is a simple diagram of the routes around your station. Your station is the larger ring. Train numbers sit on the lines, with a direction such as N or SW. The colored names along the bottom are the routes. The arrow at the top is north.

Tap a train number to open that trip. no corridor yet means the routes have not come in. Leave the page up.

Clock

The large time includes the seconds. Under it is the day and the date. The card in the middle is your station. Under that is the nearest train and how far it is.

The clock follows the station you set. waiting for live clock means the time has not come in yet. join wifi for the clock means it is not on the network.

Setup

Tap SETUP. You get three tabs: DISPLAY, LOCATION, and ABOUT.

Location

HOME STATION is three letters. Tap a letter to step it to the next letter. If the letters match a station the desk knows, the city fills in.

The arrows under the code step through the stations already stored. custom means those three letters are not one of the stored stations. You can still use it. TYPE LAT and TYPE LON set the spot yourself.

The line under the numbers is a reminder. Trains, the depot, and the map all use this spot. The clock follows it too.

If you pick San Francisco, the desk also watches Emeryville. That is where those trains stop.

Tap APPLY STOP when the station looks right. The desk saves it and starts over with trains and the map for that place.

Display

RANGE is the same circle as the zoom on the map. Minus and plus change how far out you look.

STREET is an ordinary map. SAT is a satellite picture. OFF leaves the routes on a plain background, which is easier to read in some rooms.

DARK and DAY change the look of the screen. Day is the light background. Dark is for a dim room. Changing this also reloads the map so the picture matches.

LIGHT is the brightness: LOW, MED, or HIGH.

WIFI on this row opens the join page, if you need to change networks later.

About

This page shows the version that is on your desk, and the words Amtrak / VIA / Brightline.

CHECK looks online for a newer version. If you already have the newest, it says this is the latest. If a newer one exists, tap INSTALL. Leave the desk plugged in. Do not unplug it while it says it is downloading.

Reset

Both resets are on the JOIN WIFI page. From the map, tap SETUP, then WIFI.

RESET WIFI forgets the network name and password. The station, the range, and the look stay as they were.

FACTORY clears all of it. The network, the station, the range, the map, day or dark, and the brightness go back to the way the desk arrived. It restarts, and the station goes back to Fresno until you change it.

A few things that are normal

The map is a downloaded picture of the ground. It is not a live camera. It loads again when you change the zoom or the look.

The desk remembers your station and your settings when you unplug it. It does not remember the trains. Those load again each time it starts.

Distance is in nautical miles. Speed is in miles per hour.

The list only includes trains inside the range you set. Zoom out if the area looks empty and you expected more.

Set the station before you trust the clock.